intervention, or did the Soviet intervention lead to an increase in US and Pakistani intervention? This dilemma, Indira Gandhi's pro-Soviet tilt as a response, and the ensuing debate around this response split India's political and diplomatic circles. Having already lost its reputation of being a leader of the NAM, Gandhi's Afghanistan policy came under intense criticism domestically. According to the advocacy coalition framework (that guides the analysis and arguments of this book), India's policymaking establishment had been divided into divergent advocacies that competed for influence on policy output. Existing literature on this issue argues that the 'Afghanistan imbroglio revealed the paradox of Mrs. Gandhi: international rejection coinciding with domestic approval of her policy'.[60] It is true that Gandhi had support for her policies, but only partly. Having won a solid 353 seats (out of 542) in the 1980 general election, the Congress (I) had the mandate to follow through on its foreign policy.[61] In contrast, the Janata Party had gathered a mere 31 seats whereas Janata Party (Secular) received 41 seats. Undoubtedly, the supporters of intervention won influence on policy output, however, unlike what the existing literature claims, fell far short of winning the debate. The Afghanistan question had broken the sacred foreign policy consensus that existed in India. Occurring on the plank of non-alignment and within the structural confines of Cold War politics, i.e. US and Chinese arms supply to Pakistan in the wake of Soviet intervention, debates in the Parliament of India (and outside), in early 1980s laid the foundation for the rise of partisans and conciliators in the Indian foreign policy establishment on the Afghanistan question (as detailed in the next chapter).

Gandhi's u-turn was intensely criticised by the Janata Party, the Janata Party (Secular), the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the Lok Dal, and from within the Congress. Top bureaucrats such as diplomat Brajesh Mishra and foreign secretary Jagat S. Mehta (before Ram Sathe) were also staunchly opposed to the decision. Mishra, who had announced the change in India's decision at the UN, was so embarrassed that after his speech he left the UN office from the backdoor to avoid uneasy questions, and later quit his job in protest. Jagat Mehta, who was appointed FS during the 'Emergency years' in April 1976, frantically lobbied with Gandhi and Sathe in January 1980 (though he was out of office by then) to condemn Soviet actions unequivocally.[62] He worried that pro-Soviet partisanship